



The Role of Social Movements in Shaping the Future

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Abstract

This study aims to highlight the role of social movements in transforming the future of societies, given their close connection to issues of global community development and the desire to change existing conditions. To achieve this, the descriptive approach was employed to uncover and interpret the facts and relationships associated with these movements. The study concludes that the reality of societies today is markedly different from that of the past, and may differ as well from the present and the future. This is due, on the one hand, to the dominance of social movements over the political scene and other domains, and, on the other hand, to the decline and weakening of political parties in fulfilling their assigned roles.

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1. *Introduction*

The study of social movements has evolved throughout history at an unprecedented pace, eventually becoming one of the most prominent fields of research. By the late 1940s, scholars had already noted the “shallow descriptive level of understanding and the relative absence of theory.” In the 1960s, it was further argued that “social movements had received relatively little attention within the study of social change.”

Consequently, research into collective action came to be regarded by the mid-1970s as “one of the most vibrant and active areas of sociology.” By the end of the 1980s, commentators were already speaking of “an explosion in the last decade in theoretical and empirical writings on social movements and collective action.”

Today, the study of social movements has become a firmly established field, with Today, the study of social movements has become a firmly established field, with specialized journals and entire sociological book series devoted to it. Although the intensity, enthusiasm, and optimism that characterized the mobilizations of the 1960s have long since waned, the social and political events of the past four decades

have not diminished the importance of analyzing popular activism, or weaken the pressing need for it. On the contrary, social movements, protest activities, and more broadly, political organizations not aligned with major political parties or trade unions have become a permanent feature of Western democracies. Protest policy, public participation, and symbolic challenges can no longer be described as “unconventional.” In fact, references to what has been termed a “social movement society” appear increasingly plausible and relevant in both the present and the future.

However, In the past two decades, an international trend toward the formation of social and political movements has emerged to the extent that this century has been described as the century of social movements. This trend has transformed both silent groups and traditional interest groups into movements, enhancing the legitimacy of these social organizations to the point that they and their activities have become defining features of modern democratic societies. The rise of these growing forces has reshaped the political public sphere and redefined many concepts related to political processes and their forms, within a populist and elitist

orientation that challenges existing systems and conditions (D. Della Porta, 2006:166)

Thus, Social movements may be considered rational responses to new or emerging situations in society, as they aim to renew political and social life and to provide living conditions superior to those currently in place.

From this perspective, social movements can be seen as pressure forces for reform, progress, and the creation of a new reality grounded in an alternative system of values that transcends the contradictions societies face whether in political, economic, social, or even cultural domains.

This paper therefore addresses the following core problem: To what extent do social movements contribute to shaping the future? What mechanisms do they employ in this process? And what are the distinctive features that enable these movements to act effectively on the global stage?

2. The Concept of Social Movements:

Many scholars in political sociology trace the term social movements back to the German sociologist Lorenz von Stein in his book *The History of The Social Movements in France (1789–1850)*, in which he defined them as the “efforts

undertaken during the French Revolution to bring about change and build a new society.”

Charles Tilly provided one of the most widely cited definitions in the field. He describes social movements as “a sustained series of interactions between power holders and persons speaking on behalf of a popular base lacking formal representation, during which these persons broadcast clear demands for change in the distribution or exercise of power, and reinforce these demands through public demonstrations of support” (Tilly, 2005: 15).

Herbert Blumer (1969) defined social movements as “that form of social activity which often begins as vague and unorganized conceptions and sentiments, but gradually, over time, develops into a distinct entity expressing new forms of belief and collective behavior. When such aspirations cannot find an outlet through traditional channels, they evolve into organized forces seeking to dismantle existing social patterns and replace them with others more aligned with their real interests.”

Similarly, Kurt Lang and Gladys Lang viewed social movements as a form of collective action that reflects fundamental

patterns of individual behavior, encompassing broad dimensions of public life. Such movements, in their view, aim to exert effective influence on the social system by refining certain aspects of it and directing its development toward higher and more noble social goals.

Turner and Killian, for their part, defined a social movement as a type of collective action capable of driving social change to more advanced stages of development or resisting such progress and preventing it from (معن خليل العمر. 2010:49). Both of these perspectives stress that a social movement represents vital human energy, persistently working to advance the social system for the public good rather than sectional interests, while at the same time possessing the resilience to oppose the system when it ceases to serve society or when it seeks only to benefit a narrow social stratum.

The phrase social movements is also used in widely varying senses. Sometimes it is employed in a purely descriptive way, referring to highly diverse processes such as women's movements advocating gender liberation, campaigns for the abolition of the death penalty, or efforts to ban certain products...etc. At other times, it claims to color the more creative (dynamic) aspects of social life, reflected in its capacity for

mobilization, collective action, and innovation.

These two approaches are not fundamentally irreconcilable, but the latter carries a universalizing ambition that often generates ambiguity. Social movements are at times analyzed in holistic terms, as the outcome of "collective forces," and at other times in individualistic terms, as the result of a combination of individual actions, emotions, and strategies.

It is important to recall that the history of every social movement begins with a phase of mobilization or aggregation. Mobilization itself may be understood in at least two senses. As Karl Deutsch explains, it refers, on the one hand, to a social condition marked by increasing geographic mobility (internal migration) and occupational mobility. In addition, a society undergoing mobilization is characterized by a faster circulation of ideas and more frequent communication across hierarchical divides that had previously limited contact. Thus, in societies on the path of mobilization, once accepted options become increasingly subject to a decision driven by personal bias. (ر. بودون وف: 1986. 257). For example, a young villager in the mountains, who until then saw no horizon beyond that of the

traditional community, decides to seek work in the city or along the coast. In the sense used by Deutsch, the “mobilization” of society constitutes one of the preconditions for the emergence of social movements though it is not sufficient on its own. Individuals must also free themselves from traditional constraints and develop organizational capacities that enable them to define common goals and to pool the resources necessary to achieve them.

Social movements, more precisely, the actors and participants whose activity constitutes the phenomenon itself. Are distinctive both in relation to the rules they seek to change and in relation to the values they carry. Value systems are, at least in part, embodied in laws and norms. For a normative system to be legitimate, however, it must rest on preferences presumed to ensure their fulfillment.

The opposition between a utilitarian and an idealist conception of social movements is therefore misleading. One must be cautious of romanticized interpretations that explain the coherence and momentum of the social movement solely through the leadership of its leaders, the subjectivity of their convictions, and the radical uniqueness of their mission. Equally, it is essential to avoid one sided explanation that reduce

participation in a given movement either to purely idealist motives or to purely utilitarian or romantic ones.

According to Azza Khalil, social movements in the Arab world exhibit certain particularities that distinguish their definition from Western conceptualizations. Chief among these is the societal context in these countries, which often hinders the emergence of popular movements one of the core manifestations of social movements. As a result, most movements in the Arab world are essentially elitist in nature. Moreover, the majority of these movements lack a clearly defined program of action that reflects a systematic political vision for change. Instead, they advance factional or societal demands that call for reform, but generally do not seek positions of power though some of them do (عزة خليل: 2006: 76).

Despite scholarly disagreements regarding the essence of the concept of social movements, there is a degree of consensus on certain distinctive characteristics, the most important of which are:

1. They constitute deliberate collective efforts undertaken by groups of individuals who share common beliefs and interests, seeking to achieve specific goals that cannot be

- realized by any one member acting alone.
2. They reflect the conscious will of their members. The very need for change within a given organization presupposes the presence of groups aware of and attentive to this need, and therefore willing to work toward fulfilling it.
 3. They aim to bring about some form of change in the existing social system.
 4. They require at least a minimal level of organization (إيمان شومان:1996. 84).

This distinction invites consideration of another term closely related to the concept of social movements namely, the political party. A political party is characterized by having a (relatively) clear political program addressing political issues. While it is possible for a pressure group to operate under the umbrella of a political party, the latter maintains a relatively cohesive formal organization. However, a party does not necessarily represent the interests of the entire nation; rather, it consists of individuals who seek to attain political power. This means that party objectives are often linked to the interests of certain local

or national groups within the society in which it emerges. In other words, it reflects the national interests of society to some degree, which here a new distinction becomes apparent between political parties and social movements: some movements may have little direct relation to local or national society, while others may connect national society with a wider, even global, majority. Furthermore, there exist international movements that transcend national boundaries altogether.

The concept of social movements also approaches that of public opinion, which represents a broad social group lacking a formal social structure but possessing fluid and often ambiguous boundaries. Such groups tend to emerge in response to particular issues or goals that their members hope to see realized. In this sense, public opinion can be regarded as a seed (or nucleus) of a social movement, possessing the potential for growth and development.

2. The Causes of Emergence of Social Movements:

3.1 Social Hardship or Social Injustice:

These arise when existing social institutions fail to achieve their goals and fulfill their purposes. A clear example is the Great Depression of the 1930s, which

exposed deep social and economic problems for millions of people who were left without work, regardless of their skills, expertise, or education. Massive unemployment spread, social values weakened, and individuals fell into psychological distress and depression. Industrial, commercial, and financial institutions proved incapable of absorbing the economic downturn, prompting many people to join social movements as a way out of their economic and social plight. A similar situation can be observed today with the spread of poverty, disease, unemployment, and the inability of civil society including political parties to effectively address these problems.

3.2 Social Fatigue or Strain:

This results from a widespread sense among individuals that their lives lack stability and security. Their future appears uncertain, ambiguous, and precarious, making social life increasingly difficult to comprehend or navigate due to its instability and disarray. Under such psycho-social conditions, individuals often turn to social movements as an outlet to escape the strain and exhaustion weighing them down. This can be referred to as an intrapsychic problem.

3.3 Personal Dissatisfaction:

This arises when individuals fail to realize their personal aspirations or see their desires unfulfilled, generating a sense of dissatisfaction. This in turn produces anxiety, which manifests in daily behavior and suppresses their ability to express creativity and innovation. Such frustrations can be described as a frustration problem.

3.4 Diversity of Alternatives in Collective Action:

This refers to the emergence of multiple organizations and social groups, differing in their goals, sizes, and structures, which claim to defend society and address its economic and social crises. In such circumstances, individuals may feel lost or uncertain about which organization to join in order to pursue their ambitions and potential. A similar phenomenon occurred during the Great Depression in the United States in the 1930s, when numerous groups and associations competed for membership and support (السيد الحسين: 166.1984).

3. Models of Social Movements in Contemporary Societies:

The historical period spanning from the early 19th century until the mid-20th century witnessed the dominance of three major historical social movements: the

historical peasant movement, which emerged during the feudal era; the labor movement, which arose with the rise of industrial capitalism; and the national liberation movements, which were formed in the context of imperial colonialism. However, during the latter half of the past century, these three historical movements entered a process of decline, losing their political and ideological hegemony, in contrast to the emergence of a vast and seemingly endless number of other social movements, which were politically, intellectually, and organizationally independent from these historical movements.

At the international level, economic, cultural, and human rights tensions led to the rise of numerous human rights social movements, among them the human rights movement such as “International Movement for a Just World” (known by its acronym JUST). From this perspective, some of the new and active social movements that have emerged since the last quarter of the past century and continue to the present may be highlighted as follows:

3.1 Médecins Sans Frontières (Doctors Without Borders):

This organization provides international humanitarian assistance and is a non-governmental body headquartered in Geneva, Switzerland. It was founded in 1971 by a small group of French doctors and journalists who believed that all human beings have the right to medical and humanitarian care.

It is an international medical and humanitarian movement whose primary mission is to deliver medical aid to those suffering from crises around the globe. The movement relies heavily on volunteers, being independent of all states, governmental institutions, and political, economic, and religious influences. Today, it is considered one of the largest humanitarian organizations delivering emergency medical assistance across various medical, social, and humanitarian fields.

Volunteers of the movement also provide direct field testimonies, through voice and image, on the consequences of natural disasters as well as human-made catastrophes such as wars and armed conflicts. Since its establishment, millions of donors worldwide have

pledged their support, either through occasional contributions or regular donations, thereby ensuring the continuity of financial resources and full independence in the execution of medical and humanitarian programs in the field. www.msf.org

3.2 Green Party:

A Green Party is one of the political parties widely known for raising environmental issues. Other causes often championed by green parties include women's rights, opposition to capitalism and modernity, the construction of nuclear power plants, and the testing and production of nuclear weapons.

Green parties are primarily active in industrialized nations, with some of the strongest found in Europe. One of the most influential is the German Green Party, which has become a leading force among green parties worldwide. Other countries with established green parties include Australia, Austria, Bulgaria, Finland, France, Italy, New Zealand, Norway, and several others across Europe.

This party maintains that today's industrial societies are driven by market gains and short-term profit, which in turn destroy the very foundations of human existence: the air, water, soil, forests, plant and animal life, energy resources, and even underground rivers and lakes all sacrificed for economic interests. Accordingly, the Green Party aspires to build a future free of conflicts, wars, and ecological as well as economic crises a world governed by peace, harmony, and human coexistence with nature.

<http://mousou3a.ed.ucdz.com>

3.3 Human Rights Movement:

The Human Rights Movement in all countries of the world draws on the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which was adopted and proclaimed by the United Nations General Assembly in December 1948. Recognizing the inherent dignity and equal and inalienable rights of all members of the human family is declared to be the foundation of freedom, justice, and peace in the world. The disregard and contempt for human rights have resulted in barbarous acts

that have outraged humanity's conscience. The highest aspiration of humankind, therefore, is a world where individuals enjoy freedom of speech and belief, and where they are free from fear and want.

The member states have pledged to cooperate with the United Nations to ensure the progressive respect and observance of human rights and fundamental freedoms. The General Assembly thus proclaimed the Declaration as a common standard of achievement, to be pursued by all peoples and nations. Every individual and institution is called upon to promote respect for these rights and freedoms through education, awareness-raising, and continuous measures—at both national and international levels—to guarantee their universal recognition and effective implementation.

<http://www.huqualinsan.com>

3.4: The World March of Women:

The central objective of this movement is to eliminate all forms of oppression against women, within the framework of a broader social and cultural transformation. The movement was initiated in 1996, with one of its most

notable actions being the 2000 March against poverty and violence. The years 2005–2006 marked a turning point in its history, as it organized large-scale mobilizations across the globe around the Charter for Humanity.

Since its inception, the movement has sought to unify women's movements at both local and global levels, encouraging grassroots women to engage in activism within a perspective that challenges neoliberal globalization. This is because the World March of Women is itself a product of globalization, while globalization continues to reinforce pre-existing forms of exploitation and oppression.

Currently, the movement brings together more than 6,000 groups across 165 countries, diverse in their visions and methods but united under the broader framework of the March. Presently, the movement is working towards organizing a global march advocating peace and standing against war, patriarchy, and violence.

4. Social Movements, Globalization, and the Future:

There is no doubt that the social movements that began to spread after

the Second World War particularly in the second half of the twentieth century such as feminist and post-feminist movements, anti-nuclear and anti-weapons of mass destruction movements, as well as movements supporting the independence of colonies and the improvement of living standards in the Global South, among others previously mentioned, all revolve around issues that transcend narrowly defined material demands. Some of these movements have even set global or planetary objectives, seeking to change certain conditions across the entire planet rather than limiting their focus to a specific class or geographic area.

In every case, these movements arise from contradictions within society, whether local or global. Such contradictions may be economic in nature as in earlier movements or cultural, ethical, and value-based, as seen with more recent ones. What unites them all, however, is their opposition to prevailing conditions, which they perceive as unjust or unacceptable. For example, the Civil Rights Movement in the United States was a reaction to the

degrading and oppressive circumstances imposed on African Americans. Similarly, it is not necessary for all new movements to be rooted in, or influenced by, Marxist ideology and its emphasis on class struggle. Some are instead strong expressions of collective identity, cultural values, and distinctive ways of life, rather than reflections of established ideologies. Moreover, most participants in these movements tend to come from the middle class rather than the working class, and their aims are generally geared toward greater social liberation rather than purely material gains (أحمد أبوزيد: 2010. 251).

It may, therefore, be difficult to interpret new social movements through the lens of most classical sociological theories on the subject. These movements are no longer confined to a particular society or political system. Instead, they are characterized by their wide reach, with some extending across the entire globe and encompassing diverse societies and cultures. Despite differences in fields of activity and levels of demand, they are united by a strong awareness of the shortcomings and failures of modern material civilization in addressing the

needs of contemporary humanity, its future aspirations, and its conception of human dignity and the conditions for realizing it.

As a result, by the late 1990s, global social movements emerged, including anti-globalization movements and many others whose future contours remain difficult to predict. Yet these may ultimately contribute to the emergence of the “global citizen,” a development that could lead to the erosion of concepts such as nation, national belonging, and geographical nationalism (أحمد أبوزيد: 2010. 251).

New social movements thus embrace broad, universal objectives relevant to the peoples of the planet especially as today’s economy has become a “global economy” where state interests frequently collide with one another or with those of ethnic groups. These movements, with their global outlook, seek to transcend such partial conflicts. This is particularly evident in the attention some Western global movements direct toward the Global South, where poverty, famine, disease, environmental degradation, and mounting debt call urgently for change.

It is clear that these movements recognize that the prosperity and progress of the West are deeply tied to resolving the crises faced by the Global South and to fostering its economic, political, and social development. The modern and future world is one, bound together by an integrated and interdependent unity. Many of these new movements view the world as a whole, even when progress occurs at the local or national level.

It may seem surprising that some of these movements, emerging in the West, raise demands and slogans that appear to run counter to Western interests, yet align with the broader good of the international or “global” community. For instance, environmental movements call for limiting industrial economic activity and even tourism, which often damages natural environments and exacerbates pollution in regions prized for their beauty and ecological purity. Others advocate for compensating former colonies for centuries of exploitation, including the cancellation of crushing debts. This has even led to the provocative question, still unanswered: who truly owes whom?

5. Media and Social Movements:

Studies have demonstrated that there is a particular significance in the relationship between the media and social and political movements. At this level, the role played by the media is central in introducing movements, promoting their objectives, fostering their growth, and securing their success. From the very notion of a “movement,” it becomes clear that isolated individuals cannot succeed on their own. Masses, however dissatisfied or eager for change, do not automatically constitute a movement. What is required is interaction and the building of social networks, which are closely tied to the use of communication channels.

Research has further confirmed that if a social or political movement fails to capture the attention of the media—or if journalists deliberately choose to ignore it—it will struggle to succeed. Media plays an indispensable role in amplifying protest, drawing public attention to ongoing issues, and shaping perceptions of events. Conversely, when media withdraws its coverage and shifts focus to other matters, movements

are often relegated to being seen as outdated and irrelevant.

According to the contributions of Wolfsfeld (1993) and Gamson, media coverage constitutes a decisive variable in the management of asymmetrical conflicts, serving protest movements across six key dimensions:

1. Mobilizing allies and supporters: This requires generating a public discourse around movement-related issues, reframing them as matters of collective concern rather than the interests of a narrow group.
2. Legitimizing the movement's ideas, principles, demands, and activities: Media announcements shape public perception of protest, opposition, rebellion, unrest, and terrorism, thereby influencing how society evaluates the degree of deviation or threat posed by the movement to the established order.
3. Granting social status to leaders, intellectual figures, and members of the movement.
4. Assigning significance to the movement's issues: Through

media attention, a movement gains visibility within the broader political discourse, positioning it as a notable and influential actor in public life.

5. Shaping perceptions of protest success: Media plays a vital role in defining the criteria by which the effectiveness and achievements of a movement are judged.

6. Expanding the conflict arena: While the weaker side is likely to lose within a narrowly confined conflict, broadening the arena introduces a third party—the general public—whose involvement can alter the stronger party's strategies of conflict management and control. This expansion may also generate sympathy or alignment with the movement's ideas, thereby increasing the number of supporters and allies (إيمان) محمد: 66.2011.

On the other hand, media interest in these movements is not solely due to their role as social forces, but also stems

from market imperatives of journalism circulation, profitability, and the inherent nature of news values that favor drama, controversy, political struggle, and the human-interest stories that accompany them.

Conclusion:

Undoubtedly, the future of contemporary social and political movements depends, to a large extent, on their ability to mobilize, attract, and sustain support from diverse social forces. Equally, it hinges on their capacity to adapt, innovate, and refine their methods of action to deepen their engagement with the masses and channel collective willpower toward change.

At the same time, their success is tied to the global public's awareness, discernment in evaluating reformist claims, and willingness to endorse the most constructive among them.

For these movements to effectively reshape the future, two critical roles emerge. First, they may foster the rise of a new generation of unionists with a distinctly political orientation, who will contribute to reshaping governance systems worldwide. Second, through

escalating waves of protest, they may succeed in enforcing new equations within political systems, rendering them more democratic and more open.

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